



Projective identification and “telepathic dreams”

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ABSTRACT

Based on the pioneering works by Freud and other authors with regard to telepathic dreams, and specifically those related to Klein’s projective identification and latterly developed by Bion and Grinberg, the author reviews some concepts associated with the theory of intersubjectivity. An example of a telepathic dream that emerged within an analytic process is integrated with these concepts in order to propose several hypotheses about their genesis. The main hypothesis is that projective identification and counter-identification, in their normal and abnormal forms, are the oneiric basis of communication. One member of the analytic pair transmits unconsciously to the other the contents of his real life, and the other one dreams about it; this way the dominant emotions and phantasies are made conscious. An emotionally intense climate, especially with abandonment phantasies, is required to achieve this type of communication. These dreams, infrequent in analysis, underscore intersubjective creativity, the “analytic third” described by Ogden. The author mentions some concepts based on neuroscience and quantum physics as possible explanations for the biological basis of unconscious communication.

KEYWORDS

Intersubjectivity;
contemporary kleinians;
countertransference; dreams;
phantasy; projection;
containment/reverie

Introduction

From several experiences, both with analysands of mine and as a supervisor of candidates, the topic of “telepathic dreams” has especially stood out to me. At first, I attributed these dreams to chance, but after carefully observing them and taking them together as a group, I have come to realize that they are, in fact, enigmatic psychoanalytic events that should be investigated, given their surprising accuracy in some cases.

I agree with Servadio (1956, p. 393), who states that, “Nobody could seriously deny that telepathy is an unconscious process,” thus it is a phenomenon that psychoanalysis should study, and it is my hope that this paper can contribute to this aim.

Although the term “telepathic dream” tends to be rejected in the scientific sphere as being associated with the paranormal, it has been used for almost a century in the relevant psychoanalytic literature, dating back to Freud. I will therefore continue to use this term to refer to the existence of the manifest content of dreams featuring elements of real life that the dreamer could not know about by means of any *apparent* sensorial communication. This content can bear a sometimes astonishing similarity to real life, or use symbolism

that is very close to reality. And I say *apparent*, because we do not know if there are other sensory forms of communication, as Bion (2005, p. 64) indicates when commenting on these types of dreams: “we have to become aware of the possibility that there are other receptor organs of which we are not aware.”

I shall only refer to telepathic dreams that occur during psychoanalysis. To do so, I will describe a personal experience of an analytic process in which a dream like this occurred that particularly stood out to me. I will then present some observations about its likely genesis, based on the interplay of projective identifications and counter-identifications within an intersubjective conception of the analytic process.

Freud (1921, 1922, 1933) opened the psychoanalytic door to an understanding of the telepathic phenomenon and used “telepathic dreams” and “thought transference” interchangeably, integrating them into the same topic: the unconscious transmission of thought. For him, this issue was an ongoing concern and led to some conflicts with colleagues, as described in his biographies (Jones 1957; Gay 1988), as they feared that the general public would associate psychoanalysis with esotericism and thus be considered non-scientific. Despite this, he spoke of an irresistible inclination to study it, and that it “was the great experiment of my [Freud’s] life” (Gay 1988, p. 445), though in his writing he says that he had never experienced a telepathic dream in his analytic work. Massicotte (2014) has reviewed the scientific community’s critiques of Freud at that time and reports some observations about the errors he made in addressing the issue of telepathy.

There is an extensive literature on this topic, including the work of Eshel (2006), who offers a very thorough review of the relevant analytic work. I will thus limit myself to addressing the publications that are directly related to the hypotheses I propose here.

I refer first to Balint (1955, p. 32), who described an occurrence common to analyses in which these dreams arise: “in all cases ... there was a particular emotional situation between the analyst and his patient Usually the patient was in a state of intense positive dependent transference, which however was not fully appreciated and understood by the analyst.”

Servadio (1956, p. 393), who studied telepathic dreams for more than 25 years, summarizes their characteristics as follows:

- (i) it should be unconscious; (ii) it should occur under impelling transference conditions due to physical or emotional frustration; (iii) it should be promoted by the feeling that these conditions must be overcome in order to establish communication, and by the impossibility to do so by less regressive means; (iv) it should convey an emotional message which is felt to be urgent and important.

He also adds that, “in telepathy, the subject of the experience is invariably linked to another person by a connection implying a transference-countertransference situation ... , i.e. by a strong emotional pattern of relations which involves both” (p. 394).

Mayer (2001) has published writings by R. Stoller, who died before they could be published. In Stoller’s conclusions, after recounting several telepathic dreams that occurred during his analytic experience, he indicates that almost without exception “the dream occurred during a separation [between the analysand and the analyst]—over a weekend, after an hour was missed, or during a time when I was away for an extended period” (Mayer 2001, p. 650).

Eshel (2006, p. 1620) shares a series of clinical experiences in order to present an interesting hypothesis about the origin of such dreams. She says: “The telepathic dream is created in *the gap between absence and loss*, between separation and all-out complete absence; it forms a search engine to seek and find the analyst” (italics in original).

As the focus of this paper is also related to the psychoanalytic theory of intersubjectivity, I highlight some key concepts of this theory, focused on M. Klein’s line of thought. I shall refer to the intersubjective vicissitudes resulting from the mechanism of projective identification (PI) (Klein 1946; Bion 1967), projective counter-identification (PCI) (Grinberg 1962), Baranger and Baranger’s (2008) psychoanalytic field, and Ogden’s (1994) analytic third. These contributions constitute the theoretical framework for the discussion I develop further below.

Clinical material

Below, I discuss the example that has served as the basis for my description of the possible origin of telepathic dreams within the analytic process. Though I have had some analytic experiences with these types of dreams—not only personal experiences but also with accounts of similar cases by candidate analysts I have supervised—I have chosen the following case of a patient who was in analysis with me for several years, as it has been especially significant for me.

The patient was an adult, a dental surgeon by profession, whose father had died when he was four years old. He had no siblings and was living with his mother when he started analysis. The issue that brought him to psychoanalysis consisted of episodes of severe anxiety related to homosexual encounters that made him feel intensely guilty and were blocking him in his professional and social life, to the extent that he had stopped working and had socially isolated himself for extended periods of time. He was a brilliant professional who had won several awards for his contributions on new surgical techniques in his specialty. From the first interview, I noted his high level of intelligence, agreeable manner, and clear motivation to undergo psychoanalysis following his readings of Freud.

At first, the analytic process developed with a predominantly positive transference relationship expressed in an indirectly seductive attitude, and only after a time did hostile fantasies emerge that had been camouflaged by his initially empathic attitude. The main issue consisted of homosexual transference fantasies that caused him a great degree of anxiety when they became conscious. These fantasies affected the countertransference, creating moments of impasse for me as I felt overwhelmed by their intensity—they confused me and led me to remain quiet as I worked them out. These countertransference blockages were progressively overcome as a result of my own acceptance of these fantasies. In Bion’s (1967) term, I was able to “think them,” or as Bollas (1987, p. 33) would say, they were fantasies that were “known but unthought,” which could then be thought by the analytic pair, which meant the level of communication between the analyst and analysand developed through a shared growth of thinking.

After several years of analysis, the anxiety attacks started to disappear as a result of an increasingly less guilty examination of his fantasies and homosexual behaviour. A new transference anxiety then appeared in response to his ambivalent desire to be a father. He felt that it was easier for him to find a woman, get married, and have children, but at the same time, the woman was not a sexual object for him. At that time, by chance, he met a former analysand of mine at a social gathering and began a

romantic relationship with her, with the intention to get married and have children. His unconscious fantasy was that by marrying her—that is, my daughter—he would perpetuate my paternity not only of him, but also that he would have a wife-sister that would help him fulfil his Oedipal fantasies. I wanted to prevent this relationship, as I felt that this former patient was being deceived, but deep down I understood that behind my intention were frequent homosexual fantasies and fantasies of castration and abandonment—both transference and countertransference—that created a fluctuating emotional state in the analytic pair.

Analysis began to stagnate, and the analysand started to provoke in me a feeling of apathy with respect to his affective void, with increasing monotony in his accounts, which made me feel that my interpretations were apparently accepted, but that there was an underlying insincerity in this acceptance. This led to a growing lack of interest on my part, with the sense that I could do nothing more in this analysis, and I began to increasingly want to discontinue the treatment.

Several months went by like this, and I decided to have another psychoanalyst supervise the case to see what his opinion would be. One weekend I visited an older mentor who suggested that it was not worth it to continue with this analysis. I became quite pensive and unsure of what to do.

The next Monday, the patient started the session saying:

Last night I dreamt that I was in an operating room watching a patient have heart surgery and that the surgery suddenly got very complicated with the risk of the patient bleeding to death and the surgeon called another surgeon with more experience to help him and this surgeon told him that nothing could be done and that he should leave things the way they were, the surgeon didn't know if he should take this advice and he eventually decided to continue with the operation and in the end the patient survived.

I was astonished and perplexed by this, and remained silent for a long time, listening to the patient's associations, which were related to issues around his work and his fear of failure in the surgeries he had scheduled. I maintained an attitude of "reverie" (Bion 1962) to try to see what was happening inside me as a result of this totally unexpected description. Ultimately, I interpreted that he was afraid that I would fail as his surgeon and that I would decide to abandon the surgery without finishing it. He was silent for a long time, and then his associations started to revolve around the progress he had made as a professional, though at times he wanted to stop performing difficult operations due to his fear of failure. This was interpreted as fear that we would address difficult topics, such as his desire to have children, to which he responded that his desire was mainly because he wanted to have relationships with people who would always be at his side. I then showed him that in the same way, he wanted to always have me at his side, and that our failure would be me abandoning him.

His analysis continued for several years after that.

Discussion

I refer below to some contributions that have been useful for me to comprehend this dream phenomenon.

I start with Odgen's (1994, p. 9) description of the "analytic third." He writes:

This conception of analytic experience is central to the current paper: the analytic experience occurs on the cusp of the past and the present, and involves a 'past' that is being created anew (for both analyst and analysand) by means of an experience generated between analyst and analysand (i.e. within the analytic third).

He adds:

The analytic third is a creation of the analyst and analysand, and at the same time the analyst and analysand ... are created by the 'analytic third' (there is no analyst, no analysand, and no analysis in the absence of the third). (p. 17)

In a later paper, Odgen (1996, p. 892) writes:

However, in recent years, it has seemed increasingly important to supplement this view with a perspective that places the analysis of dreams in the context of an understanding of the dream as an intersubjective analytic event From the vantage-point of the concept of the intersubjective analytic third, the question of dream analysis in general, and the handling of dream associations in particular, becomes an even more interesting and complex endeavour than had been generally appreciated.

Indeed, in the recounted dream, there is a staging of an intersubjective experience such that, like in a theatrical piece, what is happening in the pair's unconscious is acted out in the manifest content. The dream is thus jointly created in an intersubjective dynamic, with the recounted telepathic dream being a demonstration of this dynamic.

The intense emotional state of the analytic pair, especially related to fantasies of abandonment, has been identified as one of the triggers for these dreams by a range of authors, included Balint (1955), Servadio (1956), Mayer (Stoller) (1991), and Eshel (2006). This is corroborated in the example described here.

This shared emotional situation is usually experienced unconsciously by the analytic pair through the transference–countertransference process, but preverbal communication that can become conscious can also coexist.

Another aspect of these enigmatic dreams is the similarity between their manifest content and the analyst's real life, as I have noted on several occasions and as described in some of the dreams recounted in Mayer (2001) and Eshel (2006). In these recounted dreams, there were details of the analyst's real life that the analysand had no way of consciously knowing. As a supervisor, I have learned of dreams with names of people, places, addresses, and numbers and genders of members of a group that the dreamer could not possibly have known.

This raises questions such as: why is this special emotional state a trigger for this patient? On what does the greater or lesser degree of similarity between what occurred in the external world and what was dreamt depend? I shall expand on some theoretical considerations in an attempt to respond to these questions.

The mechanism of PI described by Klein (1946) constitutes the central element of the analytic pair's unconscious communication. In this communication, not only is transference an essential element, but so is countertransference, as Heimann points out (1950, p. 81): "the analyst's emotional response to his patient within the analytic situation represents one of the most important tools for his work." This is complemented by the theory of intersubjectivity, which indicates that this is also useful for investigating the unconscious of the analyst.

The importance of PI in the intersubjective vicissitudes in analysis was explained by Baranger and Baranger (2008), among others, when they presented their theory about the “psychoanalytic field.” They write: “the analytic couple depends on the process of projective identification and the unconscious phantasy of the bi-personal field is an interplay of projective and introjective identifications and counteridentifications” (p. 808).

Bion (1967) then enriched our understanding of PI with his discussion of two forms of this mechanism: “normal (realistic)” and “massive (excessive)” (p. 103, 114). The former is the basis of all communication, and the latter fulfils an essentially evacuative role. The normal is carried out thanks to the “alpha elements,” and the massive, thanks to the “beta elements.” He adds: “Yet the failure to establish, between infant and mother, a relationship in which normal projective identification is possible precludes the development of an alpha-function and therefore of a differentiation of elements into conscious and unconscious” (Bion 1967, p. 115).

Hinshelwood (1991) emphasizes the “essential” importance the differentiation between these two forms has had for the development of PI theory, clarifying that the normal is essentially communicative, and the massive (abnormal) is evacuative, which work simultaneously. There is, then, a quantitative difference that becomes qualitative; it “depends on the degree of violence in the execution of the mechanism” (p. 184).

Another mechanism that derives from the above mechanisms was postulated by Grinberg (1962, 1979), who called it projective counter-identification. In PCI, the analyst, depending on the intensity of the analysand’s PIs, can come to identify with these PIs. In discussing this, he focused exclusively on Klein’s (1946) PI without referring to Bion’s normal PI. In effect, Grinberg emphasizes that this mechanism is characteristic of the schizo-paranoid position, and he explains how the analyst, when receiving the “extreme violence of the projective identification mechanism of the analysand ... suffer[s] the effects of such an intensive projective identification, and ‘counter-identif[ies]’ himself [with them], in turn” (1962, p. 437). The analyst is thus overwhelmed by the analysand’s PIs and is unable to work them out (think them), leading to a tendency to counter-act. Grinberg (1979) indicates that “the ‘projective counteridentification’ will have different modalities related to the [patient’s] respective modalities of the projective identification” (p. 179). These PCIs are subject to the analyst’s threshold of tolerance for receiving the patient’s PIs.

In this order of ideas, I consider it also necessary to differentiate between two modalities of PCI, one abnormal (evacuative) proposed by Grinberg, and another that is normal (communicative), in line with Bion’s differentiation between PIs. Just as there are normal PIs, there must too be normal PCIs, depending on the depressive position with which a member of the analytic pair receives and works through the patient’s communications, thanks to the capacity of each for “reverie.” One receives normal PI from the other, counter-identifies with it, they feed off one another, and a shared thought development is created; namely, the “alpha-function” (Bion 1962, p. 25) within an intersubjective fluctuation.

There are thus two levels of a relation in the analytic pair. One is normal-communicative, and the other is abnormal-evacuative, both created by the analysand and analyst’s normal and abnormal PIs and PCIs. These mechanisms, intersubjectively produced by the analytic pair, constitute the unconscious communicative essence.

I return to the dream I have recounted. How could it have occurred? I believe the central dynamic is based on the interplay of normal and abnormal PIs and PCIs I have described. Let me explain. The transference-countertransference climate is dominated by diverse fantasies that generated significant amounts of anxiety in both the analysand and the analyst. By falsely accepting my interpretations, the analysand sought to inject me with the abnormal PCI of a sterile penis, telling me of a pseudo-‘insight’ so that I would not highlight his own fantasies of sterility. The emotional countertransference response was one of apathy, which concealed a certain degree of depression, as I felt that the analysand was withdrawing—that he was abandoning me by making me feel useless.

Seeking out an older analyst to advise me on what to do constituted a manic defence on my part, through which I could recover a filial relationship and thereby feel protected by a paternal figure, allowing me to “kill” my son-analysand but with the authorization of a father-supervisor; that is, denying my filicidal guilt. By counter-identifying myself (abnormal PCI) with the fantasy of sterility, I tried to get rid of the patient as retaliation for his attack, thereby depriving myself of having a son-analysand; in other words, accepting that I was unable to be his father-analyst and discontinuing the analysis for this reason. When the dream occurred, I realized that a part of the analysand’s Self wanted me to fight to understand him, accept him as a son, and therefore continue to be his father-analyst so that we could work through the fantasies of sterility he had deposited in me.

I summarize below the dynamics of the unconscious fantasies that developed in the episode I have just recounted. There was a double use of PIs and PCIs. On one hand, there was an abnormal PCI that led me to counter-act. At the same time, there was simultaneously a normal PI with which the analysand was communicating to me that he did not want to be abandoned by his father-analyst. I received this message through my normal PCI and in turn, through my normal PI, I sent him a message in which I told him that I did not want to abandon him. This message was received by the analysand, which generated the manifest content of the dream, symbolically constructed in the surgical environment in which he engaged professionally. The unconscious anxiety that the threat of abandonment produced in the analysand was elaborated through the dream symbolizing process. The interplay of normal and abnormal PIs and PCIs within an unusually intense emotional situation is the dynamic basis that generated these dreams.

It is known that all of an analysand’s dreams constitute valuable elements to elucidate the ongoing analytic process. But telepathic dreams, given their special emotional characteristics, are exceptional expressions of intersubjective experience that help the analyst become fully conscious of the process and promote an intersubjective change. A “commensal” relationship such as that described by Bion (1970, p. 95) is thus developed, consisting of the mother–baby pair providing mutual feedback in pursuit of their growth and mutual benefit. My analysand’s dream helped us (him and me) to work through the special and intense emotional situation that was developing within our intersubjective experience. In short, the analysand fed me with his dream, and I was able to understand, grow, and then feed him.

The joint creation of these dreams is discussed by Bion (2005) when he explains a telepathic dream reported by a participant in the Italian Seminars. The explanation is that

"[this dream] originates in the relationship between these two people ... how *rational* that would be, how in accordance with theories of transference and countertransference" (p. 64, italics in original). Racker (1957), too, refers to this unconscious interaction in the analytic pair when he says there is "a connection between the two unconsciouses, a connection that might be regarded as a 'psychological symbiosis' between the two personalities" (p. 321). Not only is it an intersubjective interaction, but it is also intrapsychic, as Green (2000) and Bolognini (2004) point out; that is, not only are there changes corresponding to the relationship, but also to the internal world of both the analyst and the analysand.

In synthesis, I believe that the fundamental fact in this communicative phenomenon is the unconscious intersubjective process, in that these dreams do not only occur because the analysand has a transference experience of abandonment, but also because the analyst is, in turn, overwhelmed by his or her own anxieties, and the dreams form a type of intersubjective dream production in the face of the trauma experienced by the analytic pair.

I would like to stop to comment on an aspect of Eshel's (2006) work related to whether it is necessary for there to be verbal thought development in order for this dream material to occur. Eshel recounts five examples of telepathic dreams in patients she analysed, suggesting that these dreams occurred in people who had suffered an important early affective loss or absence, which caused them a very primitive trauma at a time when the child did not have the capacity to verbalize. She adds that telepathic dreams appear when there is an experience of abandonment by the analyst, and that this is, in turn, related to a history of early abandonment in childhood, especially by the mother. I corroborated this hypothesis in the case of my analysand, but unlike Eshel's cases, it was the father who was lost at an early age, when the analysand already had verbal language. Nonetheless, the trigger of fantasies of being abandoned by the analyst was apparent.

Does this type of communication correspond to a very primitive level of development, when there is still no capacity to verbalize? This is what Eshel (2006) suggests by taking up Freud's hypothesis about the level of communication that takes place in the telepathic phenomenon, and she agrees with him that it is a highly archaic mode of communication. When discussing her patients' early losses, she says: "this ... catastrophe resides in a world of primal attachment, in a non-verbal or pre-verbal period, with an ensuing fixation on an archaic, symbiotic mode of communication" (p. 1619). But how to work through the manifest content of a dream if there is no level of verbal communicative development—that is, if there are no symbols? For this communicative exchange to exist, there must be some development of symbolization, and therefore, there must be at least minimal verbal language in order to work through the manifest content of dreams, as in the example I have given. In the case of my patient, I unconsciously sent him a message constituted by my thoughts (verbal language), and the patient received it and transformed it into the manifest content of his dream. Taking Bion's Grid (1977) as a reference, there must be a certain degree of thought development in level C of the Grid, what he would call "dream thoughts," for this dream phenomenon to occur; that is, a state in which the symbolization already exists and thus the creation of the manifest content is viable at an already developed symbolic level, even more so if we take into account that these dreams are produced intersubjectively.

Conclusions

I consider it to be evident that a mind can transmit content to another mind, and that this other mind can work through it in dream formation. This process is unconscious and forms a part of what Freud called “unconscious communication.” It is communication with “dream thoughts”—level C in Bion’s Grid.

The fundamental unconscious psychological mechanisms of this dream communication are normal and abnormal projective identification and counter-identification. Projective counter-identification not only constitutes a response mechanism to the analysand’s evacuative PI, as has generally been considered; rather, there is also a normal PCI in both the analyst and the analysand, which allows them a level of communication typical of the depressive position, thanks to “alpha-function.”

The intersubjective process promotes the creation of these dreams due to the peculiar syntonic communication between the unconscious of the analytic pair. They are a joint creation, triggered by specific emotional moments, and they constitute a distinct expression of Ogden’s “analytic third.”

In the example discussed here, intense and fluctuating transference and countertransference anxieties accompanied by an unconscious fear of abandonment triggered the dream. This conclusion is consistent with that put forward by other authors.

This unusual dream manifestation leads to an exceptional countertransference experience, through which the analysand allows the analyst to become aware of complex situations that are occurring within the process. These dreams thus facilitate the repair of a counter-action and promote an enriching “commensal” relationship for both the analysand and the analyst, as was the case in this example.

The dynamics I have described are an attempt to present some hypotheses about the origin of these dreams from a psychoanalytic perspective. The fact that one mind can receive content from another mind without any *apparent* sensory mediation continues to be an astonishing and intriguing phenomenon. I have no doubt that other sciences, such as neuroscience and quantum physics, will identify its organic basis, helping to elucidate the biological mechanisms that are complementary to the psychoanalytic explanations that have driven previous work, this paper, and surely future research as well. All of this will contribute to developing a scientific understanding of this dream phenomenon.

Translations of summary

A partir des travaux pionniers de Freud et d’autres auteurs sur les rêves télépathiques, et en particulier les travaux qui sont liés à l’identification projective théorisée par Klein, puis développée ultérieurement par Bion et Grinberg, l’auteur passe en revue certains concepts qui sont associés à la théorie de l’intersubjectivité. L’exemple d’un rêve télépathique apparu au cours d’une analyse est mis en regard avec ces concepts afin d’envisager différentes hypothèses relatives à leur genèse. L’hypothèse principale est que l’identification projective et la contre-identification, dans leurs formes normales et anormales, constituent la base onirique de la communication. Un des protagonistes du couple analytique transmet inconsciemment à l’autre les contenus de sa vie réelle, tandis que l’autre la transforme en un rêve et c’est ainsi que les émotions et les fantasmes prédominants deviennent conscients. L’établissement d’une communication de ce type requiert un climat émotionnel intense imprégné essentiellement de fantasmes d’abandon. De tels rêves, une occurrence rare dans la cure, mettent en évidence la créativité intersubjective, le « tiers analytique » décrit par

Ogden. L'auteur mentionne certains concepts issus des neurosciences et de la physique quantique qui permettraient de fournir une explication au substrat.

Gestützt auf die bahnbrechenden Schriften Freuds und anderer Autoren über telepathische Träume, insbesondere auf jene, die sich mit der von Klein beschriebenen und später von Bion und Grinberg weiterentwickelten projektiven Identifizierung beschäftigen, untersucht der Verfasser Konzepte, die mit der Theorie der Intersubjektivität zusammenhängen. Ein Beispiel für einen telepathischen Traum, der in einem analytischen Prozess auftauchte, wird mit diesen Konzepten in Verbindung gebracht, um mehrere Hypothesen über ihre Genese zu formulieren. Die zentrale Hypothese lautet, dass projektive Identifizierung und Gegenidentifizierung in ihrer normalen wie auch anomalen Form die oneirische Grundlage der Kommunikation bilden. Ein Mitglied des analytischen Paares vermittelt dem anderen unbewusst die Inhalte seines realen Lebens, und dieser Andere träumt davon. Auf diese Weise werden die vorherrschenden Emotionen und Phantasien bewusst gemacht. Eine emotional intensive, von reichen Phantasien erfüllte Atmosphäre ist Voraussetzung für diese Art der Kommunikation. Solche Träume treten in der Analyse selten auf, unterstreichen aber die intersubjektive Kreativität, das von Ogden beschriebene „analytische Dritte“. Der Autor erörtert einige Konzepte aus den Neurowissenschaften und der Quantenphysik als mögliche Erklärungen der biologischen Basis unbewusster Kommunikation.

Traendo spunto dai pionieristici lavori di Freud e di altri autori sui sogni telepatici, e facendo riferimento in particolare a quelli legati al concetto di identificazione proiettiva di Klein e alle successive rielaborazioni di Bion e Grinberg, l'autore passa in rassegna alcuni concetti legati alla teoria dell'intersoggettività. Un particolare caso di sogno telepatico emerso nel corso di un trattamento analitico viene qui integrato con quei concetti allo scopo di proporre una serie di ipotesi circa la loro genesi. L'ipotesi principale dell'articolo è che, sia nelle loro forme normali sia in quelle patologiche, l'identificazione e la controidentificazione proiettiva rappresentino la base onirica della comunicazione. Un membro della coppia analitica trasmette inconsciamente all'altro i contenuti della sua vita reale—e l'altro li sogna, guadagnando in tal modo alla consapevolezza le emozioni e le fantasie inconscie predominanti. Perché si ottenga questo tipo di comunicazione, ad ogni modo, è essenziale che si sviluppi un clima emotivo intenso—e ciò è particolarmente vero nei casi in cui a essere in gioco sono fantasie inconscie di abbandono. Questo tipo di sogni, poco frequenti in analisi, pongono in evidenza la creatività intersoggettiva, il “terzo analitico” descritto da Ogden. L'autore fa anche riferimento ad alcuni concetti delle neuroscienze e della fisica quantistica che potrebbero contribuire a spiegare il sostrato biologico della comunicazione inconscia.

Basándose en los trabajos pioneros de Freud y de otros autores sobre los sueños telepáticos, y específicamente en aquellos relacionados con la identificación proyectiva de Klein y desarrollados más adelante por Bion y Grindberg, el autor estudia algunos conceptos asociados con la teoría de la intersubjetividad. Integra a estos conceptos un ejemplo de sueño telepático emergido durante un proceso analítico a fin de proponer varias hipótesis acerca de su génesis. La principal hipótesis es que la identificación proyectiva y la contraidentificación, en sus formas normales y anormales, son la base onírica de la comunicación. Un miembro del par analítico transmite inconscientemente al otro los contenidos de su vida real, y el otro los sueña; así las emociones y las fantasías dominantes se vuelven conscientes. Para lograr este tipo de comunicación se requiere un clima emocionalmente intenso, especialmente con fantasías de abandono. Estos sueños, infrecuentes en el análisis, resaltan la creatividad intersubjetiva, el “tercero analítico” que describe Ogden. El autor menciona algunos conceptos basados en la neurociencia y la física cuántica como posibles explicaciones de la base biológica de la comunicación inconsciente.

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